

HOME GROUND
Dhami campaigning in Khatima

lack of jobs. The farmers' stir too could have a spillover effect, especially among the Jat Sikhs, who are a sizeable number in Udham Singh Nagar, of which Khatima is a part. Traditionally, the community has voted the BJP, but there is a chance it may switch loyalties. The Jat Sikhs in Khatima have roughly 10,000 votes and the Muslims another 20,000—numbers that have Dhami's team a bit jittery. On the plus side, being the incumbent CM and having the central leadership's backing has pre-empted any infighting in the local unit. Also, with the Aam Aadmi Party fielding a Jat Sikh, Swainderjit Kaler, and the All-India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen fielding Asif Mian, Team Dhami believes the electoral math is on its side. ■

PUNJAB

NO EXES BAGGAGE

It's hard times for PCC chiefs, past and present. If Navjot Sidhu is nursing a whole bunch of ruffled feathers, his predecessor Sunil Jakhar too has announced retirement from electoral politics. Their greatest common enemy is also the Congress's CM face. Sidhu at least was open about his chief ministerial ambition, but it took a viral video to expose Jakhar's aspiration—he claims he was the first choice of MLAs as Amarinder's replacement, Charanjit Channi the last. Elsewhere, the party's one family, one ticket policy left the Bajwa brothers—Partap, PCC chief till 2016, has and his sibling Fateh Jung—sulking, pushing Fateh Jung BJPward. On Feb. 3, H.S. Hanspal joined AAP and the band of unhappy ex-PCC chiefs after grandson Sundar Singh was denied a ticket. Other ex-PCC chiefs left ticketless—Mohinder Kaypee and Shamsher Dullo. ■



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI





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Shibli National College. "This time, a large number of youth leaders have become active, seeking support from all sections of society, which is a big change in Muslim politics."

Of course, it's not all honey and roses. Azam Khan, whose abrasive, combative style exemplifies the older generation, is still the Samajwadi Party candidate from Rampur. His trademark bluster is missing from UP's soundtrack though: the three dozen-odd cases against him means he has been in Rampur district jail for nearly two years. But down the narrow lane leading to his bungalow, you see crowds milling dutifully at 8 every morning. Azam Khan may be absent, but they see a reflection of his visage: his 31-year-old engineer son Abdullah Azam Khan. Released from jail just two weeks ago, he's contesting from nearby Suar Tanda. The young inheritor has taken command of campaigning in both constituencies—mingling with those morning devouts, bustling through the hi-tech party office on Baba-e-Ilm road in the forenoon, an afternoon-to-dusk whirlwind at Suar, then back in Rampur for midnight door-to-door canvassing.

He's up against another son, also pedigreed, with the Rampur ex-royalty stamp on him. Haider Ali Khan alias Hamza Mian is the Apna Dal (S) candidate for Suar Tanda—the first Muslim candidate from the BJP alliance side. Hamza's father, Nawab Kazim Ali Khan alias Naved Mian, too is in the game. The younger son of ex-Congress MP Noor Bano is contesting from Rampur against Azam—making for a first-ever direct faceoff between old rivals.

Generational change has come to Kairana too, via the same tropes of prison and a surrogate campaigner. Meet 28-year-old Iqra Hasan, an LSR graduate who went to study international law at London and caught the cameras while protesting the CAA-NRC in front of the Indian High Commission in 2019. The actual candidate, her two-time MLA brother Nahid Hasan, is in jail. They too are legatees of a family with a big place in the Muslim politics of western UP. Father: Munawwar Hasan—Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha, Vidhan Sabha, Legislative Council, he had all on his resume. Grandfather: Akhtar Hasan, who defeated Mayawati, then contesting as an independent, by over 200,000 votes back in 1984. Mother: Tabassum Hasan, ex-MP.

The family controlling the Dargah-e-Ala Hazrat in Bareilly, the hub for Barelvi Muslims, usually kept its distance from politics. Not this time. Among its fractious seniors, one supports the SP, another apparently cottoned up to Yogi Adityanath. Still, a line was crossed when Syed Asif Mian, son-in-law of dargah chief Maulana Subhan Raza Khan, filed nomination as an AIMIM candidate from Khatima. To thwart any controversy, he has been relieved of all dargah posts, but he too joins the young Muslim scions effecting a generational change in UP. ■